

Be a Competitor: Influence Your Opponent, Featuring Phillip Fulmer

Coach Phillip Fulmer

Influencing your opponent is a critical strategy to utilize as a leader. My good friend Pat Summitt said, "You can put forth so much effort that you cut your opponent down to size and force them to play below his or her own abilities. Competitiveness allows you to influence your opponent."

In order for Pat Summitt to accomplish her goal of making the 1976 Olympic team, she knew she had to perform well against players who were younger and better than her. What Pat had on her side, however, was her sheer competitive spirit. She refused to back away from a challenge and resolved to outwork and outsmart anyone who got in the way of her dream.

Competitors find a way to gain the advantage by forcing their opponents to take unexpected detours. Pat said, "Influencing your opponent is a matter of forcing them to do something they'd rather not, of making them go around instead of taking the easy path." Strong leadership requires being prepared for tough opponents. The more knowledgeable you are about your situation, the better equipped you'll be to guide your team through adversity.

This means you have to be willing to do your homework. How well do you know the competitors in your field? Do you know their strengths? How might you be able to expose their weaknesses? If you find yourself in situations where you're outmatched, use insight, awareness, and effort to force your competitor to engage with you on your terms.

True competitors practice good defense. This goes for anything in life, not just basketball. Pat said, "Defense is purely a matter of attitude. It's within your control. When two teams are evenly matched, the hustle plays can win it." To be a competitor, you have to be willing to hustle. Learn how to influence your opponents, study your competition, expose their weaknesses, and play to your strengths by spending the effort it takes to succeed. As Pat said, "The team that makes the first effort and the extra effort will win."